# WAR OF THE VARIANTS

**A variety of Omicron sub-variants and hybrid variants are floating around the world. Is the virus mutating to become deadlier? And should India be worried?**

By Sonali Acharjee



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India had approximately 17,000 active cases of Covid-19 on May 31. This figure is not a dramatic surge from mid-January, when a brand new variant—the BA.2 (assigned the Greek letter Omicron)—came to India. First spotted in South Africa on November 24, 2021, Omicron remains in the spotlight as it expands its family to include some notable sub-variants that are fuelling surges in across countries.

Omicron subvariant BA.2.12.1, for instance, now accounts for 26 per cent of the Covid genomes in the US, while BA.4 and BA.5 are spreading rapidly in South Africa, where they have been found in more than 90 per cent of the genomes sequenced. The BA.2 and its sub-variants, which mutated from the original Omicron (B.1.1.529), also caused massive surges in Hong Kong, mainland China and South Korea, where stringent lockdowns of yore had left the majority unexposed to Covid. Unlike previous variants such as Delta, Alpha or Beta, Omicron's sub-variants have made more news than the original itself. This has led many to fear that Covid is becoming 'cleverer' in its mutations and that a massive new wave is just around the corner in India. Experts won't confirm it but advise caution nevertheless.

"We do not have the surges other parts of the world have, but these waves are a grim reminder that the virus is around. It could mutate in a different part of the world or in India itself, and return as a brand new variant. We don't know this for sure, but the possibility remains. So, we shouldn't discard the culture of being careful," says Priya Abraham, director of the National Institute of Virology (NIV) in Pune.

Many had suspected that India was in the grip of a new wave at the beginning of May. Positivity rates in Delhi, Haryana and Maharashtra were above 10 per cent at the time, double the 5 per cent recommended by the World Health Organization (WHO). However, in most cases, the